

61 Making deductions

Modal verbs can also be used to talk about how likely or unlikely something is. They can be used to guess and make deductions about what has happened or is happening now.

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61.1 SPECULATION AND DEDUCTION

The modal verbs “might” and “could” are used to talk about something with uncertainty.

“Might” and “could” can be used to talk about uncertainty.

John has a sore ankle. It { might could } be broken.

The modal verb doesn't change with the subject.

The modal verb is usually followed by the base form of the main verb.



“Might not” is used to describe negative things that are not certain.

It's not very swollen, so it might not be serious.

“Not” goes after the modal verb.



“Must” is often used to speculate about the present.

John must be very bored at home. He's usually so active.



“Cannot” and “can't” are used when someone is certain something is impossible.

John's leg { cannot can't } be broken. He walked to the doctor.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Fay's got a sore throat and isn't feeling well. She might have a cold.



I was so sick last week that I couldn't get out of bed.



My eyes are itchy and I have a runny nose. It could be hay fever.



I can't have the flu because I don't have a high temperature.

